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FLAMING ROW: Hu Jintao with the torch; Tibetans protest in Siliguri

Indian soil. As Chandrashekhar Dasgupta, a former Indian ambassador to China, states: "The BJP government took precisely the same stand that the current government is taking which in my opinion is a responsible and balanced Indian position towards China."

Realising that the issue was turning nasty both China and India then worked hard to lower temperatures. Dai Bingguo, vice-foreign minister and the key Chinese interlocutor in the border dispute, called up National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan and appreciated India's handling of the issue. He requested him to ensure that adequate security arrangements were made when the Olympic torch would pass through India in mid-April. But the Government was red faced after footballer Baichung Bhutia decided to boycott the Olympic torch relay saying his sympathies lay with the Tibetans. Drawing a clear line for the Dalai Lama, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee said, "He will have the full freedom to preach religion in India but he can't conduct any political activities in the country that could negatively impact India-Sino relations."

Although the situation remained tense, a senior diplomat observed, "Both India and China behaved like grown ups indicating that their relationship had considerably matured." That is because trade between the two countries has boomed, crossing \$38 billion (Rs 1.52 lakh crore) annually resulting in China recently overtaking the US as India's largest trading partner. With the two armies regularly holding joint military exercises, confidence levels have grown. Despite frequent intrusions

across the Line of Actual Control by both sides, overall there remains a sense of tranquility on the border.

The border dispute, described as the single most important issue between the two countries, is locked in a stalemate. Worryingly for India, there has been a hardening of the Chinese stand in recent times. China has gone back to its earlier approach of making claims on Arunachal Pradesh. It has taken up the issue at the ambassadorial level and even protested when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh visited the state recently.

Chinese experts like C.V. Ranganathan, a former Indian envoy to China, are not too concerned by such developments. He believes that "while the border issue is important there is no need to treat it as urgent" and that the hardened Chinese stand means that the two sides are finally getting down to brass-tacks on the dispute.

So should India change its current policy on Tibet? Some like former foreign secretary A.P. Venkateshwaran believe that India's approach has been "too timid" towards China and that the Government has not used the Tibet issue as an effective lever. Critics of the Government's approach believe that India should use the growing international support for the Tibetan cause to toughen its negotiating stand with China on the border dispute.

Dasgupta, though, regards the tactic of using Tibet as a lever as "a brainless idea" that would lead to far greater negativism between the two countries and not help the Tibet cause either. Others argue that given India's vulnerability over Kashmir it cannot overtly support either a separatist movement or one for greater autonomy. The fact that India offered the Dalai Lama asylum has clearly put China on notice. Ranganathan feels that on Tibet, India should emphasise that China and the Dalai Lama enter into direct talks with each other, keep their demands moderate enough to find an amicable solution and let the spiritual leader return to Tibet with safety and dignity.

In 1962 when China attacked India, Mao quoted the Chinese proverb, "Out of a rain of blows, friendship flows." It's time now for China to prove it. ■

by the Chinese Government, is adopting a policy of blatant appeasement towards China with scant regard to the country's national honour and foreign policy independence."

Though the next day, much to their embarrassment, their ally George Fernandes, former defence minister in the NDA regime, in a television interview termed the decision of the Vajpayee government to recognise Tibet as a part of China "an error". Worse, many Sino-Indian experts then went on to point out that when the NDA government was in power it had endorsed India's long-standing policy that Tibet was an autonomous region of China and that the Dalai Lama was welcome to stay in India but he and his followers should not indulge in anti-Chinese activity on

STALE MATES: Narayanan with Chinese negotiator Dai Bingguo



Worryingly for India, China has of late hardened its stand on the border dispute and questions the status of Arunachal.